

CHAPTER 9

A PLEASANT INTERROGATION

'Sleep as much as you want.'

5 December 1994. My interrogation call came at 6.30 pm at the Pallipuram police camp.

Someone removed my handcuffs and escorted me to the room at the farthest end of the first floor of the Pallipuram camp.

The room had a large table and several chairs around it. M L Sharma sat at the head of the table on which were several files and papers. On his left was seated P M Nair, DIG of police. This was the man who had come to the Vanchiyoor police station on 30 November, soon after my arrest, masquerading as a journalist from outside the state.

Nair was on another official assignment, and was about to return to Delhi when he was asked to stay back and nose around before the CBI officially took over the ISRO spy case. At the Vanchiyoor police station, he was eavesdropping at the policemen and journalists who, he later told me, had bought the spy story before even questioning anyone.

Nair spoke fluently in Tamil, Malayalam, Hindi and English (what other languages this polyglot was proficient in, I knew not). He was trying to be tough, but failed miserably. He just could not hide his ingenuous cordiality, even while trying to sound tough.

Sharma again introduced himself and Nair, and the two showed me their identity cards. It was the CBI style: no intrigue about them, only a no-nonsense approach to unravelling the truth.